

HOMEOWNER'S GUIDE

5 Mistakes You Can't Afford to Make When Replacing Siding in Georgia

What every North Atlanta homeowner should know
before signing a contract.

Brought to you by Siding Depot — James Hardie Elite Preferred Contractor

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Why this guide exists

Replacing the siding on your home is one of the largest exterior investments you'll ever make — typically \$15,000 to \$30,000 for a 2,500 sq ft house in the Marietta and North Atlanta area. Done right, new fiber cement siding will last 50+ years, lower your energy bill, and recoup more resale value than any other exterior remodel.

Done wrong, it can cost you tens of thousands in repairs, insurance disputes, and premature replacement. After 1,500+ projects across Cobb, Cherokee and Fulton counties, we've seen the same five mistakes wreck budgets again and again. Here's how to avoid them.

How to use this guide: read it cover to cover before you collect quotes. Then bring it to every estimate appointment — the questions on the last page will instantly reveal which contractors you can trust.

MISTAKE #1

Choosing the lowest bid

On a \$25,000 project, the gap between the cheapest and the most expensive bid in Atlanta is typically \$8,000–\$12,000. There's a reason. The lowest bid almost always means one of three things: cut-rate labor (subcontracted day crews), counterfeit or builder-grade materials, or a missing line item that becomes a change order on day three.

What to do instead: throw out the highest and lowest bids. Compare the middle two line by line. The right contractor isn't the cheapest — it's the one whose price you fully understand.

MISTAKE #2

Hiring an installer who isn't James Hardie certified

James Hardie's Elite Preferred designation belongs to fewer than 2% of US contractors. It's the only credential that unlocks the extended 30-year transferable warranty — and it requires annual recertification on Hardie's exact installation specifications for HardieZone HZ10 (Georgia's climate zone).

Non-certified installers may use the same product, but if water gets behind the siding because the flashing detail was wrong, your warranty is void. Always ask for the contractor's current James Hardie ID number and verify it at jameshardie.com/contractor-locator.

MISTAKE #3

Skipping the rotten-wood inspection

On almost every Georgia home older than 15 years, we find rotten OSB sheathing, rim boards or sill plates hiding behind the existing siding. If your contract doesn't spell out a per-board-foot price for wood replacement *before* work starts, you'll get hit with surprise change orders mid-project — right when your house is exposed to the weather.

Ask the contractor: "What is your per-linear-foot price for rotten wood replacement, and how do you document it before invoicing?" If they hesitate, walk away.

MISTAKE #4

Letting them install over the old siding

Some contractors will quietly propose installing new siding directly over the old to save on labor and dump fees. This traps moisture, hides existing damage, and voids the James Hardie warranty completely. It also adds weight that your framing was never designed to carry.

Proper Hardie installation requires full tear-off, inspection of the wall assembly, and a continuous water-resistive barrier (house wrap) before the new siding goes up. Anything less is a future insurance claim waiting to happen.

MISTAKE #5

Paying more than 30% upfront

Reputable contractors with established supplier relationships do not need a 50% or 100% upfront deposit. In Georgia, the standard is 25–30% to lock the schedule and order materials, with the balance tied to clear milestones — typically 40% at substantial completion and 30% after the final walk-through.

If a contractor demands more upfront, it usually means they're using your deposit to finish someone else's job. That's the #1 cause of abandoned projects in our market.

Bring this checklist to every estimate

Eight questions that take 90 seconds to ask — and immediately separate the professionals from the rest:

1. Are you a James Hardie Elite Preferred (or Preferred) contractor? What is your ID number?
2. Are you licensed in Georgia and do you carry general liability + workers' comp insurance?
3. Do you use W-2 employees, or are crews subcontracted?
4. What is your per-linear-foot price for rotten wood replacement?
5. Will you do a full tear-off and install house wrap before the new siding?
6. What does your payment schedule look like — and what triggers each milestone?
7. What workmanship warranty do you provide in writing, and for how long?
8. Can I see 3 recent projects within 10 miles of my home?

Want a 60-second sanity check on a quote you already received?

Email it to office@sidingdepot.com with the subject line "Quote Review" and we'll flag anything unusual — no obligation, no sales call.

Ready for an honest, itemized estimate? — Call (678) 400-2012

Siding Depot — James Hardie Elite Preferred (top 2% nationwide), GAF Factory Certified, BBB A+. Serving Marietta, Alpharetta, Milton, Canton, Woodstock, Roswell, Kennesaw, Johns Creek and Sandy Springs since 2009.

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